

CORE FORMULA

I'm finalising the plan by Friday. Could you review the one-page version by Thursday afternoon? Even a yes/no on option B would help. -> Could you send me the exact address before 5 pm so I can book the transport? -> No pressure if your week is packed, but would you be open to a 10-minute call next Tuesday or Wednesday? -> The decision I need is A or B. Could you send your preference by midday so I can finalise it?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask for the exact action and timeframe: "Could you do X by Y?"

BEST FOR

- Work requests
- Asking busy or high-status people for help
- Delegation
- Digital messages
- Relationship logistics
- Getting stuck decisions moving
- Turning goodwill into action
- Reducing ambiguity

PHRASE BANK

Core ask · Default / specific

- "Could you do X by Y?"
- "The specific thing I need is..."
- "What would be realistic from your side?"
- "Could you send the final version, not the draft?"
- "Could you review page 2 by Thursday and tell me whether the recommendation is clear?"

Professional · Work & decisions

- "Could you review the one-page summary by Thursday?"
- "The decision I need from you is A or B."
- "Could you confirm the owner and deadline?"
- "Could you send the final version by close of business?"
- "Could you give me one-line approval or one-line objection?"
- "By 3 pm Friday, so I can finalise it before the meeting."

Digital / text · Messages & email

- "Quick ask: could you reply yes/no by Friday?"
- "If easier, just pick 1, 2, or 3."
- "Could you send the file name and deadline in one message?"
- "One sentence is enough."
- "No need for detail — just whether this direction is okay."

High-status / busy person · Time-pressured asks

- "To make this easy to respond to, the ask is..."
- "One line of direction would be enough."
- "Would it be useful if I sent a concise version for review?"

- "The only decision I need from you is..."
- "If this is not your call, who is the right person?"

Low-pressure / social · Optional & goodwill

- "Only if it is easy."
- "No issue if not."
- "If now is not a good time, I can ask someone else."
- "Would you be up for...?"
- "Completely fine if the answer is no."
- "Could you send me that link later? No rush."

Leadership / delegation · Ownership & done

- "The outcome I need is..."
- "The first step is..."
- "Please send me a two-line update by Friday."
- "What support do you need to get this done?"
- "Let's define done: X, Y and Z."
- "Could you give me one line: approve, reject, or main concern?"

Relationship / home · Shared logistics

- "Could we decide this tonight so it is not hanging over us?"
- "Could you handle the booking and I'll do the transport?"
- "What would be a fair split from your side?"
- "Can we agree who is doing what by when?"
- "Would you rather do X or Y?"

Repair / reset · Recover a clumsy ask

- "I made that too vague. The actual ask is..."
- "Let me make this easier to answer."
- "That sounded more demanding than intended."
- "I buried the ask in too much context."
- "No pressure if that timeline does not work."
- "A no is okay. I just wanted to ask clearly."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Can you help?
Better: Could you look at this?
Best: Could you review page 2 by Thursday and tell me whether the recommendation is clear?
- Weak: When you get a chance.
Better: Sometime this week.
Best: By 3 pm Friday, so I can finalise it before the meeting.
- Weak: Any thoughts?
Better: What do you think?
Best: Could you give me one line: approve, reject, or main concern?
- Weak: I need this urgently.
Better: I need this soon.
Best: The actual deadline is Friday because the booking closes at 5 pm.

DECISION TREE

If If they say yes

Confirm who does what and by when, and thank them specifically.

"Great — so you'll send the reviewed page by Thursday and I'll finalise Friday. Thank you."

If they say no

Accept it cleanly; ask about an alternative only if appropriate.

"Completely fine. Thanks for telling me straight."

If they are vague

Narrow the ask to a concrete choice.

"Would Thursday or Friday be more realistic?"

If they delay

Reduce the friction or clarify the real priority.

"If it helps, a one-line yes/no is all I need today."

If they seem pressured

Release the pressure and restate that a no is fine.

"A no is okay. I just wanted to ask clearly."

If they counteroffer

Clarify the new action and close the loop.

"That works — so you'll do X by Monday instead. Shall I confirm that?"

SCENARIOS

Casual / social

Keep it light and genuinely optional. — "Could you send me that link later? No rush."

Professional

Lead with the ask early, then add the context. — "Could you review the one-page version by Thursday?"

High-status person

Respect their time; narrow it to a single decision. — "The only decision I need is A or B."

Guarded or resistant person

Reduce the pressure and ask what would be realistic. — "What would be realistic from your side?"

Digital / text

Open with "Quick ask", give a deadline and an easy reply option. — "Quick ask: could you reply yes/no by Friday?"

Conflict

Validate the concern first, then make the behavioural request specific. — "I hear the worry about time. Could we agree who does what by Friday?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You have not yet worked out what you actually want
- You need consent or buy-in before assigning any action
- The other person needs safety, privacy, silence or practical help, not a task
- Physical safety or an emergency response takes priority
- You would be using clarity as cover for pressure or control
- The relationship needs listening or repair before any ask lands

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the vague ask

Catch and write down three vague or pressured asks you would normally make today, such as "Can you help?" or "When you get a chance."

Day 2 — Build the clean version

Rewrite each one as action + timeframe + reason + easy reply option. Name the real deadline, not a fake one.

Day 3 — Cut the padding

Trim each clean ask so the action comes first and the context is one line, not a paragraph. Delete anything the person does not need to act.

Day 4 — Say it out loud

Speak each version once in a normal voice and drop anything that sounds demanding, guilt-laden or over-polite.

Day 5 — Three-rep drill

In real life, use one low-stakes ask, one professional ask, and one recovery line after a request that landed badly.

Day 6 — Make the response easy

Send one request built around a single yes/no or a two-option choice, so the reply takes the other person seconds, not minutes.

Day 7 — Calibrate and release

Make a clean ask, then pause, read the response, and practise accepting a no cleanly without adding pressure.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask for one clear action?
- Did I name the timeframe?
- Did I explain why it mattered without overexplaining?
- Did I make the response easy — a yes/no or a simple choice?
- Did I preserve choice if the ask was genuinely optional?
- Did I confirm the next step, and notice whether it actually helped?